



Three-year-old Taher

“We had two choices—either return to our hometown in Gujarat, where my grandfather lived, because we could not afford to stay in an expensive city like Calcutta, or face starvation. My mother, despite being uneducated, was determined to educate her children. I believe that who I am today is largely because of her,” shares Taher.

But what could an eleven-year-old schoolboy do to provide for a family of five?

“My mother went around the locality asking for work for me. At 12 years old, all I could do was teach young kids. One kind lady in our neighbourhood gave me my first break and asked me to teach nursery rhymes to her son. She paid me one rupee per lesson, and since I worked every day, I earned 30 rupees in the first month. That was my first salary,” recalls Taher.

His income supplemented his mother’s earnings of 100 rupees from stitching and knitting. “Our total household income was just 130 rupees for the first few months. It was barely enough to survive—we could not even afford an egg a day

for our family of five. We did not have proper clothes, and we could not even pay our school fees,” he recalls. While survival was somehow contrived, the purpose of this hand-to-mouth living was to ensure that no Madraswala kid would have to forego their education. Taher’s parents approached the principal of St. Joseph’s College in Bowbazar, requesting assistance with school fees or a possible reduction.

“Our principal agreed and allowed us to continue on the condition that we would pay the fees whenever we could, with an extension of up to two years to clear our dues,” he says.

However, Brother James also warned Taher about his academic performance. “Up until seventh grade, I was just scraping by. If I passed, my mother would celebrate by distributing sweets at home. That was the bar we had set!” he smiles, recalling his youthful idiosyncrasies.

This warning, coupled with a mere thirty rupees as salary, forced Taher to rethink his choices.

“Baa Baa Black Sheep was simple, but 30 rupees a month was not enough! So, I started teaching first graders, then second graders, and eventually third graders. Within a year, I developed a knack for

teaching, and instead of teaching one child, I started tutoring six or seven. My earnings increased to more than 300 rupees per month. We were finally able to pay our school fees, though we still could not afford rent or proper meals,” he narrates.

By the time he reached the ninth and tenth grades, he had established himself as a trusted tutor in the locality. “People paid me 100 to 120 rupees per student, and I had 10-12 students, earning around 1000 rupees a month. This was a significant amount at that time, during 1977-79. With this income, we could pay off old debts and slowly stabilise our lives.”

Choosing duty over dreams

With a flourishing tutoring business, young Taher had found a way to support his family whilst continuing his education. But as he finished school, a critical question loomed—what next?

Taher’s first preference was medicine. “I had heard that doctors earned well and were highly respected. Coming from a business community, there were no engineers or doctors in my family, so I thought this would be a good path,” he recalls.

However, his father had other plans. “My father insisted that I pursue engineering instead of medicine. He believed that becoming a doctor would take too long—seven to eight years—whereas engineering was a shorter route. He also worried that if I studied medicine, our household income would drop because I would not be able to earn while studying,” says Taher.



Taher with his school friends in Kolkata